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# Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Thursday, April 23, 2026

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**[00:00:03]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

**[00:00:11]** Chamber.

**[00:02:09]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

**[00:03:36]** Senate chamber.

**[00:04:14]** Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

**[00:05:23]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

**[00:06:46]** Senate chamber.

**[00:07:29]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

**[00:10:03]** Senate chamber.

**[00:10:34]** Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

**[00:11:44]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

**[00:13:50]** This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

[00:16:56] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:18:10] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

[00:20:11] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

[00:23:21] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:24:27] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:25:36] Senate chamber, this is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:28:36] Senate chamber, the Senate will come to order.

[00:30:12] The senators will please take their seats. Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance will please stand. If you are able, we will rise for a moment of silent prayer.

[00:30:37] Please remain standing. We will be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by Jeffrey Naharro, Fiscal Technician in the Senate Clerk's Office.

[00:30:55] I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America and to the Republic of Stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:31:21] The Clerk will call the roll. All those present will please vote aye. The Clerk will close the roll.

[00:31:38] You have a quorum, Madam President. The clerk will report a certain communication on the desk. Commonwealth of Virginia Executive Department Proclamation.

[00:31:53] In accordance with the provisions of Article 4, Section 6, Article 5, Section 5 of the Constitution of Virginia and the powers thereby vested in the Governor to call a special session of the General Assembly, I, Abigail D. Spanberger, Governor of Virginia, do hereby summon the members of the Senate and the House of Delegates, Constitution, the General Assembly of Virginia, to meet in special session in their respective chambers in the Capitol at Richmond, commencing

[00:32:23] the 23rd day of April, 2026, for the purpose of completing the 2026-2028 biennial budget and appointments subject to confirmation of the General Assembly, given under my hand as Governor of Virginia and under the Lesser Seal of the Commonwealth at Richmond this 20th day of March, 2026, and in the 250th year of the Commonwealth.

[00:32:56] Abigail D. Spanberger, Governor. The Senate is operating under the rules of the Senate adopted at the commencement of the 2024 session.

[00:33:11] The chair now recognizes the Senator from Hampton for the purpose of taking up a resolution. Madam President, I move that the rules be suspended, the Committee on Rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution, the readings of the title and engrossments be waived, and Senate Resolution 2001 be taken up for immediate consideration.

[00:33:34] The question is, shall the rules be suspended, the Committee on Rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution, the readings of the title and engrossment be waived, and Senate Resolution 2001 be taken up for immediate consideration?

[00:33:53] as many as are in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll I was 36 does zero eyes 36 no zero the rules are suspended to take up the resolution for immediate consideration the clerk will read report the resolution Senate

[00:34:26] resolution two thousand one two thousand twenty six special session upper session one operating resolution the senator from hampton thank you madam president i move that the resolution be agreed to and speaking to that senator has the floor thank you madam president as noted this is our operating resolution for the special session it addresses per diem and mileage reimbursement reimbursements but also note that there is an additional paragraph addressing special session that

[00:35:00] once special session is convened for the first time the senate may stand in recess from time to time until reconvene with at least 48 hours notice by the call of the chair of the senate committee on rules and with that explanation madam president i move that the resolution be agreed to the question is shall the resolution be agreed to as many as are in favor of agreeing to the resolution will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the role

[00:35:39] ayes 36 no zero ayes 36 no zero the resolution is agreed to we've now arrived at the time in the morning hour when we have the opportunity to welcome our guests who are joining us in the gallery the senator the chair recognizes the senator from prince edward thank you madam president i rise for an introduction senator has the floor madam president joining us in the gallery

[00:36:15] today if you guys would please stand is carolyn patricia ayers and her children clifford and excuse me clifford and deborah clifford and deborah surprised their mom today with a visit to the Capitol. Ms. Ayers now lives in Charlottesville but she grew up in my district in Buckingham County so we had the the pleasure of spending a little bit of time together this morning and I was hoping that the Senate would join me in giving them the warm welcome of the Senate. Thank you Senator for that introduction and what a lovely early Mother's Day present to you Ms. Ayers. We are so delighted that you have joined us today in the Senate gallery and we're

[00:36:54] We're delighted that you have the thoughtful children with you who have taken it upon themselves to bring you here this morning. Thank you to Deborah Ayers-Brown, as well as Clifford Ayers-Brown for this wonderful gesture. We're so excited to have all three of you in the Senate gallery.

[00:37:13] And senators, I ask that we give the very warm welcome of the Senate to Carolyn Ayers, to Deborah Ayers-Brown, and Clifford Ayers-Brown.

[00:37:31] Is there any other business for the morning hour? chair recognizes the senator from Rockingham. Madam President I rise to request a leave of absence for my seatmate the senator from Washington County who's away from the Capitol on pressing personal business. Thank you senator the journal will so reflect. The senator from Lynchburg. Yes madam president I rise to inform the Senate that uh my seatmate the senator from Botetot is away on pressing personal business. Thank you senator the journal

[00:38:08] will so reflect. The senator from Shenandoah. Thank you Madam President. I rise to announce the absence of my seatmate from Tazewell who is away from the Capitol and pressing personal business. Thank you Senator. The journal will so reflect. The senator from King George.

[00:38:28] Thank you Madam President. I would ask the journal reflect that my seatmate the senator from Roanoke is away from the Capitol on pressing personal business. Thank you Senator. The journal will so reflect resolutions petitions and bills are now in order the clerk will call the calendar

[00:38:50] senate calendar for thursday april 23rd 2026 page 2 memorial resolutions the senator from eastern fairfax better president i move the memorial resolutions on pages two on page two sr 2006 through 2008 be considered a block in the usual manner waiving the reading of the resolutions thereof with the understanding that any senator desiring to move the resolution from the block will do so to the clerk's read the number of the resolution the question is

[00:39:25] shall the memorial resolutions on page 2 SR2006 through SR2008 be considered in the block in the usual manner waiving the reading of the resolutions thereof with the understanding that any senator desiring a resolution be removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the title of the resolution. All in favor of that motion, we'll say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The resolutions are now before us in the block. The clerk will read the titles of

[00:40:00] the memorial resolutions. Senate Resolution 2006, celebrating the life of Louis A. Boone. Senate resolution 2007 celebrating the life of Sandra Jean Caldwell Davis Senate resolution 2008 celebrating the life of James Bradley Boyd the resolutions will be agreed to in the usual manner all those in favor of agreeing to the

[00:40:32] memorial resolutions please rise the resolutions are agreed to commending resolutions senator from Eastern Fairfax madam president move the Commending resolutions on pages 2 through 3, SR 2002 to SR 2011 be considered in a block by voice vote, waiving the reading of the resolutions.

[00:41:01] We understand any center desiring to remove a resolution from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the resolution. The question is, shall the commending resolutions on pages 2 through 3, SR 2002 through SR 2011 be considered in the block by voice vote, waiving the readings of the resolution with the understanding that any senator desiring a resolution be removed from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the resolution.

[00:41:31] All in favor of that motion, we'll say aye. Aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The resolutions are now before us in the block. The clerk will read the number of the resolutions. resolutions 2002, 2003, 2004, 2005, 2009, 2010, 2011. The question is shall the resolutions be agreed to? All in favor of agreeing to the resolutions will say aye.

[00:42:06] Aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The resolutions are agreed to. Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The senator from Alexandria. Thank you Madam President. I move that the rules be suspended and that Senate Resolution 2012 be taken up for immediate consideration. The question is

[00:42:35] shall the rules be suspended for SR 2012 and will the resolution be taken up for immediate consideration? All in favor of that motion will record their votes aye.

[00:42:51] those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the role eyes 37 no zero the rules are suspended to take up the resolution for immediate consideration the clerk will please read the title Senate resolution number

[00:43:20] 2012 celebrating the life of the Honorable Marian van landing ham the The resolution will be agreed to in the usual manner.

[00:43:35] All in favor of agreeing to the memorial resolution, please rise. The resolution is agreed to.

[00:43:56] Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Inquiry of the clerk, does that complete our 15 minute long calendar? Yes, sir.

[00:44:13] Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The chair recognizes the Senator from Western Henrico. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for an announcement and a point of personal privilege. senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, members of the body for the announcement. I rise because I think we all agree that VPAP is a good thing for the Commonwealth of Virginia that keeps us informed. And this is an announcement that they're May 5th. Lighten up.

[00:44:42] It's just politics. Annual fundraisers coming up with Governor Spanberger and Delegate Wiley as the hosts. And so this is just an announcement to make sure that you help them out. And if you can be there I can't I got to teach the youth but if you can be there you should to help make sure that VPAP continues doing the good work it does and then point a quick point of personal privilege senator has the floor thank you madam president members the body I just came back from five days in Washington DC with 30 students for the national we the people competition and I I talked about this two years ago as well but I want to talk about it again because I don't

[00:45:18] think we can talk about good civics education enough we are blessed here in the Richmond area to have one of the best we the people programs in the country three schools that can consistently get in the top ten in the country my school Glen Allen Freeman High School and Maggie Walker this year Maggie Walker got second and Freeman got fifth in the country and I think the we the people program is a really good example of showing how good curriculum and the right teachers can make kids engaged you guys are have people walking in the halls every day that went through this program and you didn't know

[00:45:52] it maybe even one that's in this room and and the we the people program these kids were talking tackling questions like was Ramos versus Louisiana settled correctly and what does a trial by jury look like what do you think about the major questions doctrine and should judges use legislative intent when looking at major questions is the electoral college good what's up with the Quebec Act and have have Americans rightly been concerned with foreign influence throughout history and in contemporary events we're talking about meaty questions that get these kids engaged we do a better job than most states on civic education we have kids take it in eighth grade we have kids

[00:46:31] take it in 12th grade some states don't require it at all but it's a good reminder that we can always do more and that we should be looking for ways to get kids engaged because when we have good curriculum with right teachers we have people who who are invested and that's what we should want so thank you for letting me speak for a couple minutes about a program that is near and dear to my heart and hopefully near and dear to all of our hearts the chair recognizes the senator from colonial heights thank you madam president i rise for a point of personal privilege the senator has the floor

[00:47:05] madam president this week virginians were sold a bill of goods they were told that a map that would hand democrats 10 of virginia's 11 seats in congress was fairness the people who will have to live with the consequences of this map saw it for what it was on Tuesday and they turned out and they fought

against it and they were almost enough but the dark money from out of state the activist interest groups and the DC politicians barely dragged this amendment over the line and now this

[00:47:40] fight moves from the ballot box to the courthouse but before the courts decided Virginians deserve to know exactly what was done to get this scheme on the ballot before them this past Tuesday. In 2020, we as Virginians voted to get rid of the redistricting business, to take it away from politicians, and to end gerrymandering in Virginia. And in 2021, the Supreme Court of Virginia approved maps drawn in an apolitical and nonpartisan way. Those maps gave Virginia what Virginia actually is, a fairly closely

[00:48:18] divided state with divided representation but the governor wanted a map that would hand her party 10 of virginia's 11 seats in congress and she couldn't make that case to the voters straight up and honestly so they rigged the process that went before the voters let's start with the special session it was supposed to be about the budget but they stretched it out for nearly two years and then used it to push a constitutional amendment on this gerrymandering that was unlawful and the

[00:48:54] The trial court held that that process was void from the very start. Let's look at the timing of the scheme. By the time they pushed this amendment through in October of 2025, early voting had already started and more than a million Virginians had already voted.

[00:49:14] The Constitution requires an intervening general election between the first legislative passage of an amendment and the second. And the trial court held that the next valid election to actually proceed with this process is not until 2027.

[00:49:33] You don't change the rules after the game has already started. If you did that in sports, it's called cheating. If you did it in business, it's called fraud. And when politicians do it, it's a rigged process. Then look at the notice requirement.

[00:49:49] Virginia law very clearly requires that this amendment had to be posted and published months, months before any election could take place. They didn't do it. And when they got caught, they didn't pull the scheme back. They tried to rewrite the law in the middle of session to cover their tracks.

[00:50:09] And that tells you everything about this process. And finally, look at the ballot language. They didn't level with voters about what this really was. They didn't say, we want a map that gives Democrats 10 of Virginia's 11 seats in Congress.

[00:50:27] They didn't say, we want to gerrymander again. They wrapped a partisan gerrymander in the language of fairness and hoped that enough people wouldn't notice. And just yesterday, the trial court held that that ballot language was misleading, and the April 21st votes were ineffective.

[00:50:46] Madam President, this whole process was rigged from the start. The special session was rigged, the timing was rigged, the notice was rigged, the ballot language was rigged, and the governor jammed it through anyway.

[00:51:02] And the closeness of this vote on Tuesday really proves the point. A vote this close is not a green light to give one party 10 of Virginia's 11 congressional seats. If that outcome were really fair, the ballot language would not have needed to have been misleading.

[00:51:22] It would not have needed to have required a hijacked special session. It would not need to be jammed through after early voting had already begun. A measure that barely passes is not a mandate to leave millions of Virginians with one out of 11 seats in Congress.

[00:51:43] And I want to say one word directly to the Supreme Court of Virginia. This case is now before you. You're not being asked to help Republicans and you're not being asked to help Democrats. You're being asked a simpler question than that.

[00:51:59] Does the Constitution of Virginia still mean what it says? Does it still bind the people who are in power? And does it still protect the rights of the people who are out of power? Or can a governor and her party break every single safeguard in the amendment process, get caught doing it, and still claim legitimacy because they won by a sliver.

[00:52:26] If that's allowed, then nearly half the commonwealth gets reduced to a token voice in Congress. If that's allowed, then Virginia's not being governed by the rule of law. It's being governed by a majority party led by a governor that thinks it can run a rig scheme and get away with it.

[00:52:46] The Supreme Court now has a choice. It can enforce the Constitution, or it can teach every future majority in Virginia that if you move fast enough, if you hide the ball long enough, And if you mislead voters well enough, the rule of law doesn't matter.

[00:53:04] And I still believe that there are judges in this commonwealth who know the difference between the rule of law and power. And for the sake of Virginia, our Supreme Court needs to show it. Thank you, Madam President. The chair recognizes the senator from Prince Edward.

[00:53:24] Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Madam President, today we passed Senate Resolution 2010, which honors a very special woman who's spent a lifetime in service to others and whose life has a remarkable story woven through it.

[00:53:43] I introduced her briefly during the morning hour, Carolyn Patricia Ayers, who, by the way, only learned of this resolution when it was passed in the block a few minutes ago. This was also orchestrated by her wonderful children. Carolyn Patricia Ayers of Charlottesville was born in 1957 at the University of Virginia Hospital.

[00:54:05] She grew up in Dillwyn and was among the first students to integrate at Dillwyn Elementary School. In 1981, she graduated from the University of Virginia School of Law, becoming the first black attorney from Buckingham County. Over a distinguished career spanning more than 40 years, she has served in Washington for members of Congress as an assistant attorney general and judge in Delaware.

[00:54:30] and she went on to build a respected family and criminal defense practice in Charlottesville. These are just the beginning of her many accomplishments. But what really struck me when talking to her son Clifford last night is Carolyn's profound humility.

[00:54:46] He shared that even piecing together his mom's accomplishments was a little bit difficult because she never talks about herself. She's always too busy, instead of focusing on her accomplishments, creating the opportunity for others to achieve their own dreams.

[00:55:03] As a devoted mother and trailblazer, Carolyn has broken barriers with grace and determination and lifted up countless others along the way. I had the privilege of spending a little bit of time with Carolyn and her children this morning, and I can just tell you, some people, as soon as you meet them, their character just shines through, and she's an incredible woman with an incredible heart, and I really appreciate her and her children giving me the opportunity to share this moment with them today.

[00:55:32] Thank you, Madam President. thank you senator for those lovely words and i would just ask that we in the senate recognize all that uh miss ayers has accomplished one more time thank you so much for everything that you

[00:55:47] have contributed miss ayers the chair recognizes the senator from alexandria thank you madam president i rise for a point of personal privilege the senator has the floor thank you madam president the alexandria community lost a legend earlier this month with the passing of former delegate

[00:56:26] Marian Van Landingham. Former delegate Van Landingham was a respected public servant, a devoted community leader, and passionate artist who re-established cultural life in Alexandria through her visionary contributions to the establishment of the Torpedo Factory Art Center. Former delegate Van Landingham grew up in Albany, Georgia and received bachelor's and master's degrees from Emory University in Atlanta and also pursued formal education in the fine arts at the Art Institute of Atlanta. She began her career in public relations with Emory University and the Georgia Institute of Technology, then worked for federal agencies and served as a press aide and speechwriter for a member of the United States House

[00:57:01] of Representatives. In Alexandria she was a pivotal member of Alexandria's emerging arts community as president of the Art League and in 1973 amid efforts to develop a larger home for the Art League she saw an opportunity to transform the former torpedo plants on Alexandria's waterfront into a working arts center where visitors could gain a greater appreciation for the arts by watching painters, sculptors, printmakers, and craftspeople hone their talents.

[00:57:26] Through her diligence, persistence, and hard work, the Torpedo Factory Art Center officially opened on September 15, 1974, and the center has not only led to a stronger sense of community along the Alexandria waterfront, but it is one of the most respected working art centers in the country, drawing hundreds of thousands of visitors every year and serving as a national model for arts driven revitalization. She was first elected to the House of Delegates in 1981 representing Alexandria and parts of Fairfax and Arlington counties for 24 years. During her tenure in the General Assembly she served as the first female chair of the Privileges and Elections Committee and as a senior

[00:58:05] member of the Appropriations Committee where she advocated for increased funding to support public education, mental health services, Medicaid, child care, services for older Virginians and the unhoused and community-based initiatives. She retired from public office in 2005 as the most senior female member of the House of Delegates. In later life she remained active in civic affairs and continued to serve as a champion for working artists at the Torpedo Factory where she was highly admired as a prolific painter and a trusted friend.

[00:58:34] She earned countless awards and accolades for her professional achievements including the 1974 Washingtonian of the Year Award and the 2024 Bernard Ben Brinman Archaeology and Alexandria Award and she was also selected as a living legend of Alexandria and as one of the Library of Virginians, Virginia Women in History honorees. Madam President, I thank my colleagues for passing Senate Resolution 2012 to remember the life and legacy of former Delegate Van Lanningham. Thank you. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Mecklenburg. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a point of

[00:59:13] personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. The recent murder of Dr. Serena Fairfax in our Commonwealth urges me to call on our legislature and administration to make

prevention and intervention of domestic violence and sexual assault and the full funding of victim services an immediate top priority in 2023 there were 792 denied shelter requests due to lack of

[00:59:43] capacity in 2024 that number rose to 1083 in 2023 72,982 hotline calls and texts were answered. In 2024, only 68,641 were answered, not because decreased demand, but because there were not enough staff to respond. In 2022, more than 78,000 calls and texts were answered. In 2023, advocates provided face-to-face services to 23,057 adults and 68,046

[01:00:17] children. In 2024, those numbers dropped to approximately 22,000 adults and 5,700 children. I can probably promise you that Dr. Serena Fairfax was a mother like me. She probably raised her children by herself even though she was married. She probably spent her entire life protecting her children from someone in her own home that she should have trusted to protect her, and she probably

[01:00:55] did everything right and she's not here to continue to raise her children today. I continue to be a survivor. I don't consider myself a victim even though I still daily deal with someone that I left 12 years ago and I'm going to continue to speak about this and I'm going to continue to be here fighting for this and even though the three years I've been here I've only been able to accomplish for victims a watered down version of cyber stalking. I'm going to continue to speak up and fight for those people that are not here like to like dr. Fairfax who

[01:01:33] doesn't have a voice anymore and I'm not going anywhere and we've got to make this a priority and I hope that you'll help me do that thank you thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from northern Fairfax thank you madam president I rise for a point of personal privilege senator has the floor thank you madam president as I was walking to the Capitol Square this morning remarking on the 250th anniversary of our great nation I was surprised that Governor

[01:02:06] Spanberger was was in the middle of a ceremony with the Nottoway Indian tribe and it was the 313th anniversary of the Spotswood treaty that was signed in February 27, 1713, and it was an agreement with the now-called Nottoway Indian tribe and the British colonial government at the time, and it was establishing peace and securing land rights for the tribe in Virginia. What a

[01:02:42] moment, right, that we still recognize and celebrate working together, collaborating, finding civil and peaceful ways to live harmoniously. And I feel like this point in time in our country and in our world, we have very few examples of that, but I was heartened.

[01:03:06] And it gave me a little bit of hope this morning that reflecting on our history and our past, we can do better and we can continue to remember what we all came here for. Thank you. you senator the chair recognizes the senator from Stafford thank you matter president arise for a personal privilege senator has the floor thank you my president to arise to speak about a pretty special team in my district the University of Mary Washington men's basketball team that they had quite an extraordinary achievement and a remarkable season culminating in the

[01:03:43] historic victory with the NCAA division three men's basketball championship on April 5th. That night in Indianapolis, the Eagles secured a thrilling 75-73 win over Emory University in the last second shot. It was pretty exciting for those of us watching. It was an unforgettable moment that captured national attention.

[01:04:05] It was featured as the number one play in ESPN Sports Center's top ten list. It was pretty cool. That victory marks the first national championship for a men's team in any sport in the University's history

and it's the first national title of any kind for Mary Washington in more than three decades. It's a milestone that reflects not only athletic excellence but also years of dedication, discipline and belief. And the Eagles finished their season with an outstanding 30 and three record including a perfect 16-0 mark at home and rose from a preseason ranking, this is one of my favorite parts of this,

[01:04:42] of 15 to claim the top spot in the nation along that way they captured a second consecutive coast-to-coast athletic conference championship and defeated the defending national champions to earn their place in the title game this team's success extends beyond the court they have represented their university in the Commonwealth with integrity and inspiring excellence in the classroom inspiring pride all across the Fredericksburg region in our community it's my honor to uh they are here on the on the capitol grounds today i know they're meeting with the governor and i'm going to get a chance to go meet with the team today so uh if

[01:05:19] you do get a chance to spot this team um love for you all to give them a warm welcome um to the capitol grounds and a congratulations thank you madam president thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from eastern fairfax thank you madam president rise for a point of personal privilege senator has the floor thank you madam president and madam president and i think i I neglected to tell you good morning when I initially.

[01:05:44] You did, sir. Good morning. Good morning. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I didn't realize we were going to be so chatty today. I thought we were going to be out of here by 10:30, but the rhetoric of the morning calls on me to respond.

[01:05:59] So first of all, Madam President, I find it rather rich that I've heard calls about anything being rigged in the Commonwealth of Virginia. the oldest, oldest legislature in our country, the oldest statement of democracy in the Western Hemisphere, the place, I think, a lot of the foundation, the state that founded the Bill of Rights, which led the Declaration of Rights, which led the Bill of Rights, which led the

[01:06:34] rights all across the world being adopted and codified. It's ironic to me, ironic, because the only rigging that's occurred in this country in the last six years has come from across the river.

[01:06:56] The only rigging of any election has come from that man across the river. Seven things I want to tell you about. Number one, the current system right now, if it's rigged in any way, number one, there was a Supreme Court state that was stolen.

[01:07:14] Some would say more. and we have a current branch of government at the federal level two branches in fact which are completely incapable of checking power checks and balances on power is something that this state was founded on the leaders of this state led the world in creating that concept people like madison and jefferson that doesn't exist at the federal level right now because that system is rigged the man across the river has also asked tried to rig the next election he's asked the

[01:07:48] the Department of Homeland Security to assemble lists of voters that only voters the federal government could say can vote, even though the Constitution of our country specifically says elections are administered by our state, the states, not by the government.

[01:08:07] He's also, number three, completely dismantled the United States Department of Justice's Public Integrity Section, which doesn't seem to even exist anymore. Number four, he directed the United States Postal Service not to expedite the delivery of mail-in ballots.

[01:08:26] He's tried to flex his muscle on mail-in ballots, something that we have promoted in this state extensively. Why would he do that? Well, if he saw the election results that happened a couple of days ago, it's pretty clear why. He's trying to rig the results.

[01:08:44] Number five, he has preemptively tried to question the results of our next election before it's even occurred to try to lay the groundwork for these kinds of calls, which we just heard in this chamber. He even claimed that the election on Tuesday was rigged when there's absolutely zero evidence of it.

[01:09:02] Beyond that, and most importantly, he's tried to rig the map, told Texas to go ahead and redraw their map so that Virginia wouldn't have a voice. So they did it in Texas, then they did it in North Carolina, and they did it in Missouri, Then they did it in Ohio, and now they're asking to do it in Florida, to try to deprive our state of having a voice at the federal level.

[01:09:34] Our country has not seen an assault on its separation of powers, on our federal system, on our democracy, anything like we've seen from this guy. And Madam President, the idea that the voters somehow didn't understand what was going on on Tuesday is preposterous.

[01:10:04] Virginians are not that stupid. First of all, I just wanna remind the body that if you remove the ninth congressional district from the last election results in 2025, Abigail Spanberger won this state by 20%.

[01:10:20] Go do the numbers. The rest of the state voted 60-40 if you take the ninth congressional district out of it. Just go do the math. The map was disclosed to the voters before they had a chance to vote on it.

[01:10:37] We put it out there. We said, here's the map that's gonna be adopted. The idea that people didn't know On Tuesday, what they're voting for is preposterous. It was right there. This is what you're voting for. It was important. We got it out two months ago. It was advertised all across the Commonwealth.

[01:10:54] You had to be living under a rock if you don't know what you were voting for. People also know how to read. They can read the ballot question. They can read lots of other resources. And a lot of money was spent trying to educate people about what the map said, Madam President.

[01:11:13] And I trust the voters of Virginia more than that. I think they know how to read. I think they know how to watch TV, listen to the radio. I think they understand how to figure things out on their own, and I trust them to make the right decision. Madam President, I would say that as we all leave today, I would suggest that everybody in this chamber, as they leave this chamber, walk out the door, right down there, and there's a statue.

[01:11:41] is a statue of a man that's sat there since this place was built a man who came from my district who led the fight in this country to fight against the exact things the man across the river would like to have happen like to go back okay born in his district but he would like but he would like he would like us to go back to a monarchy go back to a president that has unchecked power

[01:12:14] And I would suggest that, as the Senator from Northern Fairfax just mentioned, as you contemplate the 250th anniversary of democracy in this country and the assault that is being directed at our democracy, you think about it as you walk by George Washington and everything he did to make sure that we could be here in this chamber today to have the democracy that we do.

[01:12:41] Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the Senator from Rockingham. Madam President, I rise for a point of personal privilege. Senator has the floor. You know, I'm sick and tired of turning this

every time back to the man across the river.

[01:13:06] You know, it's always Trump this and Trump that. Well, this time it's about how we treat our neighbors here in the Commonwealth of Virginia. I can tell you, I've come in to this chamber, and you smile all you want, and into -- and And I know that there are those who are gloating about the outcome of the election on Tuesday.

[01:13:30] But I have come into this chamber and I've come back in November after elections where we've won. I've come back after elections where the other side has won. And when the other side has won, I have always, always been able to congratulate you and congratulate my friends on the other side for a hard-fought race.

[01:13:54] I've always done it, even where there have been painful personal defeats. I've been able to do it, but not this time. I'm not going to congratulate you for winning on Tuesday, because you know, the other side knows, that what happened on Tuesday was wrong.

[01:14:16] It was wrong how we treated people across the Commonwealth of Virginia. It disenfranchised vast swaths of the Commonwealth. imposed upon them representation by those who looked down their nose at us, at people across the Commonwealth of Virginia. We just heard the 9th District would take the 9th District out, remove the 9th District. I know that's what you want to do is put them on an island. You treat them with disdain. You don't respect them. You don't respect people

[01:14:53] in rural Virginia. You know, I know that we have a handful of people up in Northern Virginia at the hub of the spoke, reaching out, high-fiving over their ability to represent people they don't understand, they don't know, they don't care about, and it's arrogant, it is wrong, and people of Virginia are not going to sit by quietly and let this happen to them. Mark Mark my words, people are angry, and they're just going to get more angry.

[01:15:30] There will be a reckoning. It may not be today, it may not be tomorrow. If this stands, there will be a price that will be paid here in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[01:15:47] The chair recognizes a senator from Franklin County. Thank you, Madam President, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President, members of the body, to hear from my friend from Eastern Fairfax.

[01:16:03] If you eliminate the 9th District, then we win by 20. And my friend who has just spoken points out exactly the mindset that Northern Virginia, in my opinion, has for the people that I represent, where I live, where my family comes from, in Southwest Virginia and Southside Virginia.

[01:16:23] Madam President, I rise at a point of personal privilege, but I feel like what I'm doing here is to make an introduction. I want to introduce my colleagues, particularly those who represent the communities of Northern Virginia to a place that many of them have never been, a place they have voted on, a place that their policies have now shaped with this most recent General Assembly session, a place they have judged from a distance.

[01:16:53] Allow me to introduce you to Southside and Southwest Virginia. Not the Southwest Virginia or Southside of Virginia of assumptions, not the Southside in southwest Virginia of stereotypes. Not the version constructed from a cable news ticker or political talking point. The real one. Madam President, if you leave Richmond right now and you drive southwest, past Roanoke, past the new River Valley, past the

last exit where the radio stations stopped coming in very clear, you will eventually arrive somewhere different. Not just

[01:17:30] geographically different. Different in the way that people live. Different in the way of what they count on. Different in what they have lost and different, profoundly, beautifully different in who they are. There are men and women in my district who've never been to a Starbucks, not because they couldn't find one, it's because there isn't one. If you want a cup of coffee where we live, chances are the farmer next door is going to bring it to you early in the morning

[01:18:02] to have a conversation on the stoop. There are communities out there, small towns, mountain hollows, river valleys, where people still leave their doors unlocked. Not because they're naive, because they know every single person on the road they live on and they trust them. Ask yourself a question. Why do we have less crime? Why do we have less murder? Why do we have less violent felonies being committed against the people that we live with? And the answer is because of their

[01:18:39] character and their integrity. Let me tell you, if you will indulge me, who the people of Southwest Virginia are. They are the man who sees a stranger broken down on Route 19 at 7 o'clock in the morning in the cold, in the rain, who has no cell service. That man doesn't keep driving. He stops. He gets out. He gives you his jumper cables, his time, and if you're lucky, coffee in his thermos. And when you try to pay him, he's gonna look at you like you're insulting him. That's Southwest and Southside

[01:19:17] Virginia. They're the woman who looks out her window and notices that her neighbor, the one who just lost his wife, the one who's going through chemotherapy, has not mowed his grass in three weeks. So she doesn't count the county. She doesn't file a complaint. She fires up her own mower, gas-powered. Spends her Saturday afternoon on someone else's yard. And when he comes out to thank her, she says, don't worry about it. That's just who we are. That's just what we do.

[01:19:49] That's Southside in Southwest Virginia. They're the volunteer firefighters who drive 45 minutes to a structure fire at two in the morning, not because they're paid, not because there's a pension at stake, but because someone needs help and they're the ones who can give it.

[01:20:11] They're the teachers who buy supplies with their own money because the school budget doesn't cover it in our region. And they do it without complaint, without a press release, without a GoFundMe page. They just do it. The farmers who work from sunrise to after sunset, through drought, through flood, through markets that don't favor them because this land where we live has been in the family for four generations and they are not the ones who will be the last ones to farm it to provide food for their community these are not the people of

[01:20:48] stereotype these are not the people some of my colleagues imagine when they cast their votes limiting their freedoms and their rights and fundamentally changing their ways of life these are among the most decent most resilient most generous human beings that I have ever had the privilege of knowing. Madam President, I want to talk just for a moment about the land itself because you cannot understand the people without understanding where they live. On a clear night in Southside and Southwest Virginia, you can see the Milky Way. Not in a

[01:21:26] picture, not through a telescope, not at a science museum. You walk outside your front door on the porch, you look up and there it is. The entire arm of our galaxy stretched across the beautiful night sky so thick with stars it looks like someone spilled light across the dark my colleagues in northern virginia

when was the last time you saw that because i can tell you that because i live there you were lucky if you saw four or five stars with the light pollution and the noise when was the last time the sky was even dark enough and quiet enough for you

[01:22:02] to feel how small and how lucky we are to be on this good earth in my district that's not a special occasion, that's a Tuesday. We have rivers that run cold and clean through our ancient mountain gorges. We have waterfalls hidden in hollows that most of the world will never find or see. We have the new river, one of the oldest rivers on earth, winding through landscape that has barely changed in a thousand years.

[01:22:32] We have black bears, wild turkey, white-tailed deer. We have trout streams and raptors and wildflower meadows that bloom in colors that don't even have names. We have the kind of silence that city people pay thousands of dollars, hundreds of thousands of dollars to try to find. And the people who live there, they have lived it every single day. And they love it. And they're not going anywhere. They don't need a handout, and they don't need to be told how to live their lives. Madam President, I say all of this not to give a travel brochure to

[01:23:09] Southside and Southwest Virginia. I say it because Southside and Southwest Virginia has been, in my opinion, written off this General Assembly session. For far too long this corner of the Commonwealth has been treated like a problem to be managed rather than a community to be served. We are invoked when it's convenient as an example of perhaps what you think can go wrong and forgotten when decisions are made about what comes next. Many of the colleagues I serve alongside here have never been to my district as I've stated. They've never driven those back roads. They've never sat in those diners and met people just

[01:23:47] because they're there. They've never talked to the woman who drove 40 minutes to get her child to a doctor's appointment. The man who's trying to figure out how to keep the lights on after the last employer in the county has closed its doors. But they have voted on their lives.

[01:24:06] They have voted on their health care. You have voted on their schools. You have voted on their roads. You have voted on whether they have broadband or not. Their energy bills, their jobs, their futures. You voted on all of this without consulting them. And you have voted to limit their treasured constitutional rights. And some of those votes have been made with breathtaking confidence by the people who have never once asked, who lives out there? What do they need? What are their values?

[01:24:42] What are their names? Madam President, I'm not here today for asking for sympathy. The people of Southside and Southwest Virginia do not want pity. They never have. Madam President, I'm asking for something simpler. Acknowledgement. Before we legislate someone's life, let's at least try to understand it. Before we tell a community what is good for it, let's listen to them and what they tell us about themselves. Before we write off a region as a lost cause as it seems to be, or just

[01:25:19] an annoyance politically because it tends to vote in a way that you don't agree with, let us remember that there are real people out there, people with names and histories, dreams, and dignity, who are watching what we do in this chamber. Madam President, they are watching, and they are counting on us to see them. So the next time that you drive west and south, and the road starts to climb and the sky starts to open up, I want you to think about the people

[01:25:56] on the other side of those mountains. Think about the man who stopped on that side of road for the other person to help. Think about the woman who took care of her neighbor's lawn. Think about those stars you've never seen before at night because you've never been somewhere so dark and look up and see our cosmos. And then think about how you vote when those very people are counting on us, counting on you. Southside and Southwest Virginia is not a problem to be solved, ladies and gentlemen. It's not a region to be managed. It is home. It is home to us. And

[01:26:35] the people who live there deserve a government that knows their name and respects their rights and their values. Thank you Madam President. Thank you Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Roanoke. Thank you Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor.

[01:26:59] Thank you Madam President. I'm very proud to be a Virginian. I'm very proud to get to serve in this capital. I consider that a great privilege. But it's pretty rich to suggest that nothing's ever been rigged in these halls before, and that it was somehow an offense to suggest that something could possibly have been rigged in these halls.

[01:27:22] Right after World War II, V. O. Key described Virginia as a museum of democracy, said we had all the trappings that looked like representative government, but obviously was not acting here. There had been massive limitation on the franchise through our entire history, and at that point it was still continuing. Through most of Virginia's history, most adult citizens have not been able to vote. To suggest that Virginia has always gotten it right on elections, we all know not to be true. And we all love General Washington, but it's pretty amazing to suggest that everything

[01:27:59] got right all the way through. And it's especially rich to hear that just after we heard why we should change so much a few weeks ago. In this Capitol, in addition to limiting franchise over and over again through so many processes. As recently as the early 80s, we had multi-member districts that existed just to suppress populations that weren't supposed to be elected. People of specific races and people of specific political persuasions. So amazingly, this capital was filled

[01:28:36] with white Democrats overwhelmingly in a state that had a substantial non-white population and had a substantial Republican voting population, so much so that it continued to vote for the Republican candidate for president and could elect Republican governors, but a Republican veto could never be upheld because the districts were drawn in such a way by the legislature that sat here that the Republicans could win a statewide election but could not get to one-third of the seats in one chamber to sustain a veto. That was not that long ago. Virginia, we have so much to be

[01:29:13] proud of but we do not have the best record through all this and the events of this week are another time where the non-favored folks are being pushed out and it's different folks at different times but it's not right at any time to try to suppress representative government like has happened so often here the limited franchise literacy test poll tax multi-member districts not one time did this legislature say we realized that we've done wrong and we're now gonna fix it every time it took external intervention either took

[01:29:52] federal constitutional amendments or the courts and the courts need to look at what happened this week because this process was not right it was not right to have the question worded on that I have not heard one person defend to me why after every other question tells folks exactly what it is why a question would be phrased that is so slanted just for the proponents. When everyone is voting on the maps and

we're told the maps can't be at the polling location, they were not allowed inside and the only way people got to see the maps, it

[01:30:31] wasn't because of the 90 million dollars of unverified money where it came from outside of the state. It was because the folks that had a lot less money spent all their effort and time trying to make the maps visible and there was anytime there was a suggestion of is this map right it was told no it doesn't matter what the map looks like all that matters is what happens the ends justify the means we have to get to a 10-1 map this was not right again we're gonna need the courts external intervention to do the right thing because this legislature which has a long history of not doing the right thing to non-favored

[01:31:11] groups is doing it again it is incredibly disappointing to hear the majority leader of the Virginia Senate suggests that if we just remove 1/11th of Virginia from the equation, here's what the election results would be. That that's what happened for a long time, was we removed about a tenth of the population here, tenth of the population there, and here's what the election results look like. It is not right. We know it's not right, and no one that represents the leadership of this chamber should suggest that 1/11th of

[01:31:48] Virginia should not be counting our election results. That is disappointing. It is wrong. And what we need to do is get to the right thing. After all those times of who was running the government, finally, Republicans once took hold of redistricting. And in 2000, Republicans had redistricting. And amazingly, other population groups started doing a little bit better. But we were told we need to have bipartisan redistricting commission. We need to have it.

[01:32:22] This one time Republicans did it, we need to have it. So we got it, we did it, and then six years later, we're told we don't need it anymore. Madam President, I hope that our future successors will not need external interventions like our predecessors did, and that we now also need. Thank you.

[01:32:40] Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Lynchburg. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. As I came in this morning, like most mornings, I had not planned to speak, had not written anything out. But as so frequently happens, as we sit here in this chamber, someone will say something that gets my attention. And frequently, it is the senator from Eastern Fairfax who does that.

[01:33:11] And if there is still a free press in Virginia, if there are still journalists in Virginia, if there are still writers in Virginia, the headline for tomorrow's paper should be Senate Majority Leader, Democrat, Eastern Fairfax says on the Senate floor, if we could just eliminate the 9th Congressional District.

[01:33:43] If we could just eliminate the 9th Congressional District, how much will we win elections by? What difference would the state be if we eliminated the voters and did not count the votes of the 9th Congressional District?

[01:34:00] I hope that will be a headline tomorrow. And we're not going to relitigate how we got here. We know how we got here. But I will say, and I do enjoy the senator from Portsmouth's social media feed, and I see them, and I get a kick out of them, and 10 F and 1.

[01:34:32] We started it, y'all are going to finish it. Well, I will say this. If I was a Democrat, which I am not, I would not be feeling that great right now. Because five months ago, five short months ago, this governor won the race by 15%.

[01:34:55] 15%. Five months later, we got a competent RPV chair. We had an election yesterday. And y'all won that by 3%. 3%. You should be scared.

[01:35:12] Less than 3%. I don't do math. Less than 3%. And y'all think you feel good. Good. I hope y'all do. Because I'll tell you this. I have been to the 9th Congressional District. I grew up in the 6th, I live in the 5th, I've been all across the Commonwealth.

[01:35:31] And Republicans, to quote John Paul Jones, "We have not yet begun to fight." Y'all had this amendment yesterday, the 7th, where again the Senate Democrats capitulated to the House Democrats and created the lobster district for one particular delegate.

[01:35:50] carried by 0.03. 0.03 yes carried in the seventh. We're not going away. We're not quitting. We're not gonna give up. We're not giving in to 10 F and 1. It ain't gonna be 10 F and 1. I can promise you that. You've got a governor who was elected five months ago, who was sworn in four months ago in January and is now the most unpopular governor in this millennium. The second headline should be

[01:36:24] Democrats in charge of all three legislative branches, the governor, the Senate, and the House, when we adjourned on March 14th, did not produce a budget. Our only constitutional obligation as a body is to produce a budget. We left here March 14th without a budget. We scheduled a return for yesterday, for today, whatever the day is, April 23rd. I'm not used to being here in the spring, and we

[01:37:00] still don't have a budget. And more disappointing is we hear that the conferees are not conferring, that there really haven't been any conversations about the budget, certainly not for the public. Maybe some people are meeting with data center representatives behind closed doors, certainly not transparent.

[01:37:20] We still don't have a budget. We don't know when we're coming back to talk about a budget. And that is the Democrats responsibility to produce a budget. One the other bills that the and that's probably why the governor's ratings are so low even though senator from portsmouth's ratings are still fine see i do read your social media and i i can barely read um and one more bill that kind of shows the direction of what the democrats are doing to

[01:37:57] virginia and would help explain a 12 point drop in five short months 12 percentage points y'all just dropped across the Commonwealth, collective bargaining, a bill that you feel so strongly about that the House and the Senate delayed its implementation until after you get re-elected in 2027. You don't even want it to go into effect before you have to run for re-election because you know the damage it will do to our cities and our counties. You've seen what it's doing to Richmond and Fairfax. You've seen how much it is costing our localities, but that's not

[01:38:36] enough you sent the bill to the governor the most unpopular governor in this millennium at this point in their career in their tenure and what did she do with that bill she thought it was so good she signed it or she amended it to go into effect after she gets the heck out of here in 2030 have you ever seen a governor sign a bill that goes into effect in four years after she has gotten the heck out of this ticking time bomb that y'all have given the

[01:39:07] the Commonwealth of Virginia. So, you know, we talk, certainly the senator from Eastern Fairfax talks a lot about the current president, Donald Trump. I, you know, assuming he does not run for a third term, that will end, that will end at some point. And you guys are gonna have to answer for what y'all have been doing to the citizens of the Commonwealth, taking away the gun rights,

[01:39:44] putting in this union, all of the expenses, and you're trying to kill the golden goose data centers which have kept the tax rates low in many of your localities and we would like to have them down in my localities we would tell we will take them we will take them we will provide energy if we do away with the Green New Deal if we can get out of Reggie we can get affordable energy to our citizens so eventually you are going to be responsible for what you're doing take notice y'all just lost by 12% in five months based on what you've done

[01:40:20] this session. So we're gonna fight you, we're gonna fight you in the ninth, we're gonna fight you in the fifth, we're gonna fight you in the sixth. We're gonna fight in the lobster district. It ain't gonna be ten F and one. The chair recognizes the senator from Hanover. Thank you madam president. Rise for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Like many who've preceded me I was not

[01:40:54] planning on speaking but my former my colleague from my alma mater also spurred me, and I want to read y'all something that I was sent yesterday afternoon from a constituent. They write, "I came away from voting feeling completely lied to by the way the ballot question was phrased to the voters. Using the word 'fair' and they put it in quotes, was bias and judgmental trickery. Madam President, that

[01:41:28] constituent was my 81 year old mother. So when I got that, I paid attention. Madam President, I also paid attention to the trial court who ruled that that same ballot question was flagrantly misleading. Madam President, I can also read the Constitution that says a proposed amendment shall be presented not sooner than 90 days from passage by the General Assembly. I might be a little bit

[01:42:06] better at math than my colleague from Lynchburg, and I know that voting started about 43 days after that passed this legislature. So, Madam President, as we look at things, we want to talk about what was fair and straightforward and honest. The process has not been that way and certainly the caboose bill that repealed a statute all the way back to the 70s is not one that's straightforward

[01:42:40] and honest. But, Madam President, what I think that this legislative body will be remembered for are probably not those things, but they will be remembered as constituents pay more on each and every one of their power bills. As every single employer and the employee in the Commonwealth, when they get their paychecks, they will take home less money. And Madam President certainly think it's a good observation that collective bargaining, every jurisdiction, Republican

[01:43:19] a Democrat is talking about how expensive that will be and how much people's taxes on their homes and their cars will have to go up to pay it for it and madam president the fact that it will not be fully in effect until after our next election and the fact that the governor did not want it to be in effect during her entire term speaks volumes madam president we're going to see a lot more conversations about things around redistricting. I just saw a few minutes

[01:43:56] ago, there's act filed in Congress, make DC square again. So there will be continued conversations about Virginia and redistricting, but Madam President, Virginians are worried about how much money is in their pocket, and when they see that their power bills are going up, they're taking home less money, and they're concerned about their future taxes increasing, they will continue to make statements. And their statements will be, those policies are not good for

[01:44:33] us. That's not affordability and we do not want leadership that is taking money away from us. The chair recognizes the junior senator from Loudoun. Thank you Madam President. I'm raised for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. As I adhere to this debate or

conversation, I'm just reminded of something that's why we are here for, that's policy. I just want to remind everyone about a

[01:45:13] little policy that we all did many years ago about Medicaid. I got into politics because of my lived experiences with a broken healthcare system. My wife's lived experience with a broken healthcare system. We all have experienced it. It's not unique. Several of our constituents have experienced.

[01:45:34] I had the, this immigrant had an unbelievable honor of serving in Medicaid board for seven years. Just remember Medicaid expansion for a second. Just go back with the numbers. When I joined the board, it was 700,000 members. Then came Medicaid expansion after eight years of fighting. That's how I got very, very, my wife and I got very involved because of Medicaid, because of healthcare, because of expansion just look at the numbers numbers don't lie we all can read simple reports on dma's website go look at the increase in medicaid population who did it benefit i had the

[01:46:13] honor when i was in the house to be on the speaker select committee on rural health i went every nook and corner i made friends on the other side i still cherish those friendships those dinners and conversations i remember a medicaid member when we expanded adult dental care not only we expanded medicaid we expanded adult dental care a million people got the benefit i remember a medicaid member who was willing to go on film he had lost most of his teeth he wasn't working the

[01:46:47] expansion helped him he got all his teeth back and then he recorded a short film for us and then he said i got my confidence back i got my life back i got a job and he's not on medicaid just think about that that's policy but just think about what we went through i just want to remind everyone that we will fight on politics forever but policy is why we are here ultimately people

[01:47:22] look for policy ultimately people look for are their lives getting improved and i'm proud to say that we fought the good fight and i've always said this before i've said this once before in this floor last session. Loudoun is my home, but Virginia is my district. It doesn't matter where anybody is in Virginia. That is our district. That is why we are here to serve every nook and corner. I get really concerned when we try to get this argument into Northern Virginia doesn't care

[01:47:56] about Southwest Virginia. That's not true. We all come from Virginia. Every policy that we debate here benefit all of Virginians and I just want to remind everyone Medicaid expansion is the proof thank you madam president thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from King George thank you madam president and I apologize but I kind of was inspired by my friend from Eastern Fairfax does the senator rise a brief point of personal proof senator has the floor um madam

[01:48:34] President, the sad part about this to me, we've talked about the 9th and we've talked about other districts, but as a result of that referendum, 90% of Virginia has now been disenfranchised.

[01:48:52] And that's what I'm sad about. Because Virginia is a large state, there's a great deal of diversity in it, and now you have, somebody correct me if I'm wrong, seven potential members of Congress from Northern Virginia, or is it more, five from Fairfax.

[01:49:16] Don Beyer, who I'm sure is a nice guy, would represent the Northern Eck in the area that I live in, and I'm reminded, and it's not that Northern Virginia doesn't care about rural Virginia. It's that they don't spend any time in rural Virginia. They don't understand the way that we live. They don't understand why we live there. We get the rural secretary bill every year to try to help us figure out how to live better in rural Virginia, even though we love it.

[01:49:47] We have a delegate from Fairfax who brought a bill to save the turtles. Wasn't going to let us catch any more crabs. Well, we have a vibrant seafood industry. We had a bill yesterday that the governor amended to make it a class two misdemeanor. If I go dove hunting with my son and I finish and I walk in and I put my shotgun unloaded in the corner of my kitchen while I eat my lunch and a friend comes over and he has a child that's 16 years old, I'm now guilty of

[01:50:22] a class two misdemeanor and can go to jail for six months. So not that you don't like us, that you don't care about us, you don't live the way we do, and you don't understand the way we live, and that's what I'm worried about, and the people that I represent, I have 11 counties in my district, they're good people, they're hard-working people, they're honest people, they care about their neighbors, but they don't live the way people live in Fairfax, and I'm not saying that's a bad thing, I'm just saying it's a difference, and I listened to the senator from eastern Fairfax talk about the

[01:51:02] man across the river. And the vitriol strikes me. I respect the senator from Eastern Fairfax. I like him. And that's the truth. But here's what I'm reminded of an ancient Chinese proverb. And I don't know how it goes in Chinese, but I remember the gist of it. The vessel that carries hate destroys that vessel from within. And the hate against this president is such that I think it's

[01:51:41] corrupted this body. And I'll rely on the senator from Henrico to correct me, but I believe Thomas Jefferson said about our great democratic experiment, we'll be fine and we'll do well until the cities and the urban areas become corrupted as the ones in Europe are now.

[01:52:07] Madam President, this process was corrupt, and I'm not talking about it in the form, I'm using the word literally. It was a corrupted process. And I just am so afraid that the hate for this president has corrupted this body. And we shouldn't have done what we did. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes a senator from Arlington. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, arise for point of personal privilege. Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President.

[01:52:46] I find this conversation to be probably more divisive than our actual reality. At one time, that was, I guess, 12 years ago, I represented a district that was politically diverse. I had parts of Arlington, parts of Fairfax near the Potomac River, and I went all the way out to Loudoun.

[01:53:07] I had parts of Loudoun. And it was more diverse than my usual Arlington constituency. And at the same time, I was a member of the school modernization committee that was chaired by the senator from Franklin County.

[01:53:25] And the senator from Franklin County made sure that we went out to visit many jurisdictions in Southwest Virginia. And I was very happy to be part of that committee. And I went out there with the senator from Franklin County and other senators. so I made it a point to to talk to regular people even though we visited schools we talked to a lot of educators we did have opportunities for public comment at our meetings and and I found that we are much more alike than we are

[01:53:59] different individuals I I'm sure in Southwest Virginia and in Southside Virginia my son actually lives in the northern neck works for a rural school system. And they actually, they, us Virginians and all these different pockets of the Commonwealth want the same thing. They want an opportunity to be able to support their families. Whatever that venue might be, whether it be farming or manufacturing or technology, they want an

[01:54:35] opportunity to pursue their passion, to do what they're good at, and to make enough money to support their families and they want an opportunity to send their children to good public schools and that's an obligation that we as lawmakers have I think for the most part done our best to meet we have to do more but creating a good first-class education for every child in every pocket of the Commonwealth would be amazing and it would be welcome and it would be embraced by every Virginian in every corner of the Commonwealth and Virginians in every

[01:55:14] corner of the Commonwealth want opportunities for their children they want their children to be able to go to college and we have as a General Assembly have invested in our public universities and in fact we're we're ranked as one of the best states in terms of investing in public education both K through 12 and higher ed and Virginians in every corner of our if our commonwealth want their children to have opportunities to thrive they want an economy that's that's diverse and and able to offer their children a good

[01:55:51] life a good future that's what this should be about and to imply that Congress people who whenever they're whatever their district might look like would somehow not embrace those values I just think is is disingenuous Congress people, they're elected by everybody in their district, or they certainly represent everybody in their congressional district. And I have to believe that they are going to make an effort to represent a diverse district where individuals may live differently. And I know that folks in

[01:56:30] the Northern Neck don't go out the door finding Starbucks the way, you know, my son used to sort find Starbucks near where we live. But that's okay. I mean, that's fine. Nobody's making any value judgments. It doesn't mean that Virginians still don't want the same goals in life or want the same things for their families. We may have to address it differently. We may have to provide programs a little differently. I get that. But let's not lose the fact that we are really much more alike in what we want what we desire and what we expect from our

[01:57:09] government and let's focus on those things on the things that can help us build a strong community everywhere in the Commonwealth thank you madam president thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from Charlottesville madam president arrives for a brief personal point of personal privilege senator has the floor madam president like some of my friends I'd never come to this room or rarely come to this room intending to speak and I did not today I promise you that but there are a few things I do want to say you

[01:57:49] know I grew up as a member of the other body and in those days there were Democrats and Republicans from Southwest Virginia there were Democrats and Republicans from Northern Virginia there were Republican delegates from Loudoun from Prince William from Fairfax to two people that I sat in the coffin corner there. Marian Van Lendingham sat in the middle of the second section. She was very quiet and really aloof from a lot of us because we were rough and tumble and she was not. She was a serious legislator. But two people that I sat near, Tommy Jackson from Carroll County, the eastern part of

[01:58:27] Carroll County, and Toddy Puller from the eastern part of Fairfax County, formed an exchange. They They would get citizens from their parts of the state to go to the other district.

[01:58:43] They would have exchanged trips every year. You would have a group from Carroll County that would go to Fairfax, a group from Fairfax to go to Carroll to try to develop better understanding. We worked really hard because, you know, as representative of rural Virginia, we understood that if Northern Virginia and Hampton Roads ever got their act together, we were going to be in the minority always.

[01:59:08] We had to figure ways to keep the 5th, the 6th, and the 9th districts together, and we had a master leader. We did that most of the time. We did that most of the time, but not all the time.

[01:59:23] But you know, just a few points I want to make. Nobody's disenfranchised. We don't vote by the acreage. We don't represent acres. We represent people. Every person in the Commonwealth of Virginia will have a congressional representative, no matter what the maps look like.

[01:59:40] have a representative and each one of us knows that as elected representatives we have to be responsive to the people that vote in our elections so nobody's going to be disenfranchised. The second thing and I resent the notion that we haven't done anything for rural Southside and Southwest Virginia you know since probably the late 80s a portion of the recording tax has been going into a fund to pay for improvements throughout 58. That is directly money that goes to Southside and Southwest Virginia from everywhere else in the state. It goes to

[02:00:17] improve a road that will maybe never built, never finished, but we are working on it. Medicaid expansion, as my friend from Loudon pointed out, I will tell you that that is the people that are going to be the victims of HR1 at the federal level are primarily in Southside and Southwest Virginia. And if you look at the maps the dollars that we're gonna lose as a result of that bill they're primarily people that live in the what was the sixth and ninth and the fifth districts over the years and I can point to specific things we worked on in

[02:00:55] the 90s in particular but but after we the Democrats lost the majority we continued to work on found ways to drive increased funding for rural school districts in the early 90s we focused on legislation to establish and this notion of equity in school funding so we could divert more money to Southside and Southwest Virginia we weren't always successful but we've always tried we've always worked to increase opportunity for people in Southside and Southwest Virginia I just want to want to say a little bit about about Marion because

[02:01:34] you know George Washington when he was a member of the the other body the House of Burgesses. He was on the the Privileges or the Elections and Privileges Committee and up through the late 1980s the path to become Speaker of the House of Delegates was through the Privileges and Elections Committee. It was not insignificant that she was the first woman to be the chairman of that committee and that wasn't until probably well the mid-90s when the Democrats were beginning

[02:02:06] to lose control um so she she was a quiet leader and she was you know as i said aloof for most of us because the rough and tumble stuff you know i'm pretty good at and and those people those are the people i hung around with but she was serious the whole time um my point i guess of all this is that what goes around comes around people are people they're going to have representation And we're going to have divisions in this, but the divisions can't be personal, and we have to, at the end of the day, produce the best product we can for the people we represent.

[02:02:43] Thank you, Senator. Does the Senator from Stafford wish to speak a second time on a point of personal privilege? Yes, very briefly, Madam President. The chair will allow at this time. Thank you. The Senator has the floor.

[02:02:58] I appreciate it. I'll keep this very brief, but I felt compelled listening, Madam President, to a couple of colleagues talk about well my friend here from Lynchburg talked about what he hopes the headline will be for tomorrow and I don't want that headline to change if it would happen but a couple of

my colleagues have talked about the delayed enactments and I felt compelled just to share a little briefly a little bit more about that because not long ago I'm out of president I was in my district where in Stafford County the chair hosted a town hall where we could come and have folks for the committee could come listen and talk about what's happening

[02:03:32] post session and one of the big issues in my district is concern about k-12 funding they're very very frustrated about it and it right now our funding system kind of sets up a we're a winners and losers system and and stafford county is pretty frustrated about that because we're our lci formula and the uh the the coca formula is really set us up for to not be competitive to with our neighbors to the north, and the folks are increasingly talking about that.

[02:04:02] And one thing I heard from some of the newer delegates, my president, really took a lot of us by surprise, and I remember one of the constitutional officers and I were pretty stunned to say, "We understand the frustration with the K-12 formula. We're going to fix it, but it's not going to be for four years."

[02:04:18] So I would hope that our media, I would hope that that would become a cautionary tale for the future governors because it's not just on some of the bills that we have coming before us now but it's others that are coming down the pipeline clear the conversation where I'm not being privy to yet I said I haven't heard about this yet but if we have more delayed enactments on the k-12 funding formula that's going to be a repercussion for future governors who have that is they certainly should be aware of that because good policy needs to be enacted now thank you very much my president thank you senator the chair

[02:04:53] recognizes a senator from Western Fairfax. Madam president um you know I try very hard. What purpose? Oh I rise for the purpose of a personal point of privilege. The senator has the floor. Thank you madam president I try very hard to be efficient on this floor and try to get us all home so I don't speak very often but but today to hear some of the things that have been said kind of get my uh greek american blood boiling and i i hope i'll be uh eloquent in uh in what i have to say

[02:05:29] because of that i think we've heard a lot about who northern virginians are what they think what they feel um and i would like to say that uh i want to introduce you to two northern virginians one of them is my husband who is a jewish political refugee who came here in the 80s uh was stuck in the former soviet union came here under the israeli reunification program with two um luggages just that's it that was their whole life when they got here and they were

[02:06:06] very lucky to get out the second one is my next door neighbor a lifelong republican whose family is actually stuck in northern korea and the last few years both of them have been out of their minds they've been coming to me and saying what are you going to do what are you all doing our democracy is failing we are in decline our freedoms are being taken away people don't even get it they don't see it but we do because we've lived through this before we've seen the signs

[02:06:38] We know what will happen when we don't foster a strong democracy that works for everyone. And I'd like to take us back because this 10-1 debate, this redistricting debate, that's what this is about. And I know that it's difficult for those who have never needed to face these types of freedoms being stripped from you.

[02:07:02] These leaders who only care about themselves, and their egos, and their power. I understand that it's hard to say, "Well, why don't we just stop focusing on Donald Trump?" Well, we can't stop focusing on Donald Trump, because what Donald Trump is doing to this commonwealth, to this country, is taking our democracy into steep decline.

[02:07:30] that's not an opinion i know i'm not that smart but historians agree historians who spend their time looking and studying these signs in 2025 we have gone to the lowest point of strength of democracy in the way that that is counted we are no longer considered a strong democracy that should scare every single person regardless of political party regardless of NOVA or

[02:08:06] rural or or where you live or what you think or or anything that should scare us because that means we will not have the opportunity to sit in bodies like this soon and debate policies and ideas with each other that's what this 10-1 map is about and it is going to pass and it is going to go into effect and I'm just gonna say here and I hope you all remember this that after it goes into effect I bet the people of Southwest Virginia and the entire Commonwealth are

[02:08:41] gonna come back and say we have had the best representation we have ever had because we're gonna have representatives who go to Congress who fight for our democracy who fight for our health care who fight for our freedoms and who fight for our children thank you thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from Hampton thank you madam president I rise on a point of personal privilege the senator has the floor thank you madam president I will be or I

[02:09:19] will attempt to be brief madam president I guess I'm a little bit baffled because I wanted to be in Hampton by now and I am I guess I'm a little bit baffled too but all of this self-righteous dick indignation I'm hearing over what started as a conversation about the redistricting vote that took place on Tuesday and one of the things I heard first was about

[02:09:54] dark money and all of the dark money that was pouring into Virginia with regard to that. But I want to start with one thing first, and that was I registered to vote under voter suppression, and I'm very doubtful that there's any of my colleagues to my left, excluding this one, who cared one bit about the fact that I had to register under voter suppression.

[02:10:31] And so, I'm not at all enamored about discussions about disenfranchisement because I was disenfranchised when I had to register to vote. So all of this stuff about disenfranchisement, give me a break.

[02:10:49] Now let me talk about dark money. So the Thiel money and the Musk money that came into this state wasn't so dark.

[02:11:07] paid for those oxymoronic named flyers that came under the name of Justice for Democracy that filled my mailbox every other day and daily in the last two weeks with those stereotypical messages talking about what was going to happen to me as a black person if this amendment passed that was beyond

[02:11:46] propaganda. It was lies, it was innuendo, it misused the civil rights movement, it misused Martin Luther King, it misused people who fought and died for the right to vote under the name of justice for democracy. Talk about dark money. Give me

[02:12:22] a break about justice and democracy. Oxymoronic words coming from folks who are concerned about trying to get the right to vote for folks who need it. Now let me talk a little bit about why this is happening. This is a political scientist talking now. The Congress of

[02:12:57] the United States is supposed to be the lawmaking body and they have pitulated that responsibility of making laws and turned it over to the executive branch. They no longer are concerned about making laws they are only concerned about saying yes to an individual and saying how quickly can we say yes

[02:13:33] to someone you know how far can we bend our back to say yes you know they no longer make policy they simply say tell us what it is that we have to do and how quickly can we do it so they no longer are making decisions on behalf of the people this people making body is no longer making decisions on behalf of the people. So quite frankly when I talk to people about that amendment that passed

[02:14:10] on Tuesday, I talk to them about who do you want making decisions for you? Who do you want sitting in those seats? Do you want people who are just going to automatically say yes or do you want people who are going to be thoughtful deliberators and push back on decisions like HB1 that takes away your Medicaid that takes away your health care that takes away snap that takes away housing or do you want people who are simply going to say oh yes mr.

[02:14:47] president whatever you say no or do you want people who are going to be deliberative and concerned about who you are as a person and make decisions that matter to you that's what this is about it's not about maps it's about people who care about you as a human being and are going to go into Washington DC and push back and make decisions so ask your constituents why is it that you have to

[02:15:23] drive 40 miles or 60 miles to find a health care facility you know it's not because the decisions that are being made here in Richmond or in Northern Virginia we're not the ones who did it to you so let's not get this all twisted we are making the decisions that are right for you and you are going to be able to elect people who care about you and make decisions that are going to be

[02:15:58] right for you. So that's why we're here this day and ultimately the right decisions are going to be made. And happy birthday Stella. Thank You Madam President. Thank You Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Central Fairfax. Thank You Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege.

[02:16:20] The senator has the floor. And ladies and gentlemen I promise I'll take about 30 minutes of your time but I'll try to keep it brief. Madam President I did not expect to speak today but after hearing so many of my colleagues I really want to talk about what is happening in America and how people like myself and a lot of us in this chamber look at one another and how we got here and it's policies you know going back to the days that we were here policies have made you know my family homeless we lost health care we lost a lot of things along the

[02:16:58] way but at the same time good democratic policies like the affordable health care act and a lot of housing policies that come along the way where we were off the streets we were able to find housing and i remember being in this chamber uh back in 2024 when madam president uh you did my introductions and a lot of my colleagues on both sides of the aisle came by and said that is the the American story. That is remarkable. And yet, under this presidency, under Donald Trump, when there was an attack on immigrants, mass deportations, and of course, the criticism of

[02:17:37] the pre-press eluding the American people of funding across the board, every single one of you stayed quiet. But the moment the Democrats decided, hey, we want to fight back, we want to have the guts, we want to have the balls to really go out there and do things, that's when you all decided to wake up and say, we're going to fight the Democrats instead of trying to fight for the American people, instead of trying to fight for Virginians. And when I talk to people, you know, this 2026 session, I took a good beating from a lot of folks on the policies that I carried,

[02:18:15] but I get stopped at grocery stores, at Wawa's, at places where people come up to me and say, I'm thinking they're going to punch me in the face, to be honest, because of the comments I get online but they come up and they say you actually fought for virginians all across it wasn't just northern virginia and i'm reminded when my family was homeless it wasn't just a person that we knew it was people in northern virginia who did not look at us and say oh you're a democrat or republican wealthy or poor they just lend that hand and that is what this referendum is doing is going to go

[02:18:52] out there represent every single person in every district regardless of who they are regardless of what they do and that's what people are asking us to do so sure everyone's afraid of clowns everyone's afraid of an orange man but beyond that you're going to get people in rural virginia where they're going to see that people are fighting for them they're going to see health care getting back to them they're going to realize they no longer have to drive two hours three hours to go to a hospital because of funding that was cut. That is what they're getting,

[02:19:28] and I know a lot of folks in this chamber on a personal level have reached out to me over the last couple weeks with the Islamophobia and the attack that I get every single day. None of that bothers me. What it does is really it harms the people that we don't know. It divides a lot of our communities. It divides people that we have never interacted with, so I really want to also thank each and every one of you that reached out over the last couple weeks regarding that and Madam President. This body is incredible. Imagine a guy coming from a third world country who became

[02:20:04] homeless and now gets to sit in a body with extraordinary folks that have made extraordinary decisions to help thousands of other Virginians. That's what this body is about. So don't look at these referendums and things as a way to say we're going to divide Virginia. This is to unite and to ensure that we fight for America and for democracy itself.

[02:20:28] So thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the Senator from Western Henrico. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, rise for a point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, like the rest of the body, other than the Senator from Franklin, I don't think I planned any remarks here.

[02:20:48] And as many of people on the other side of the aisle were prompted by the Senator from Eastern Fairfax, I'm actually prompted by the Senator from Franklin the remarks that he made and so I want to add something that I don't think has been said here you know I grew up not in rural Virginia but I did grow up in rural upstate New York and you got that same rural urban divide there that you got here and so a lot of what the senator mentioned is the stuff that I grew up with and I recognized in his speech a lot of the condon you know the condescending rhetoric towards urban and suburban areas that he accuses people

[02:21:23] this side of the aisle for having for rural areas this this sense that rural life is more American or is cleaner or he was using rhetoric that I think a lot of people on my side of the aisle got upset with and

and I would ask folks to ponder the flip side of that equation there was a an article in today's paper New York Times about USAID and about what happened to the employees of USAID after the fallout of doge I'd ask you all to read that article and see what

[02:22:00] that meant not just for the employees at USAID right but for their families and their communities and you could expand that many fold you could look at all the doge cuts you can look at the science cuts you can look at the education cuts I get weekly emails from folks whose livelihoods are unless on the line because of stuff that the president's doing at a radiologist reach out to me yesterday about, or last week, about Medicaid, Medicare, CMS rate cuts. If you go to that USAID article, if you go to that radiologist's email, they're not saying changes shouldn't take place.

[02:22:39] They're saying the way it done was wrong. And when you put on top of that, the rhetoric of the wood chipper and the chainsaw and the glee in which that behavior was done, the way those people were treated and are continuing to be treated I would say that that probably cuts both ways and when you look at who voted on Tuesday and where turnout for the yes vote was strongest I would suggest to you that the rhetoric and the ugliness and the divisiveness and sometimes yes racism against those

[02:23:18] communities are maybe why they voted yes or maybe why they felt so inclined to go out and vote against the person across the river. You know, there's been so much selective outrage about this. I really find it stunning when you look at who started this. And you don't even have to, you don't have to take my word for it, Arie Flesher, George W. Bush's press secretary said that it started in Texas with Donald Trump and that it was a mistake. And all the people who voted yes and all the people in Virginia who came out saw through that selective outrage.

[02:23:58] they saw who started it because they're not dumb. They're not idiots. They recognize that if all these Republican states are allowed to mid-decade gerrymander with no response, these actions will continue. Their families will continue to have people fired from jobs. They will continue to have the rhetoric about how it's great to fire people and ruin lives. And so I would ask you to look at the flip side and to see what's at stake here. There is a way, as the senator from Hampton

[02:24:32] mentioned, there's a way to make reform. That's not what's happening right now. You know, in the last election cycle, the last couple of election cycles, we have been elected to govern on affordability and to push back against the madness that's coming from across the river. And we have done that.

[02:24:51] Senator from Loudoun talked about one of our long-term efforts at health care coverage. But this session alone, health care, housing, energy, the economy, we have passed legislation that'll make life affordable, and we've pushed back against the stuff that's ruining Virginia's economy. That's ruining Virginians' lives. And so, you know, that cuts both ways. Maybe people should reflect on how the folks in Northern Virginia, the folks in the Richmond region, the folks in Hampton Roads, and the people across the Commonwealth, because as Senator Hampton noted, clinics aren't closing because of us. Clinics are closing because of them. Maybe we

[02:25:30] You should consider how all those actions make people feel and how they ruin lives. Because there's a lot, there are a lot of people upset and they're right to be upset. And so, you know, I just, let's take a look in the mirror.

[02:25:49] Thank you. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senior senator from Prince William. Thank you, Madam President. Rise for a point of personal privilege as we hit the noon hour.

[02:26:06] Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Wanted to share maybe a different perspective, I think the debate today is listed out a long list of possibilities of response or rebuttal or headline suggestion or many other things, but I think in perspective what I heard and what we've done this week is actually an illustrative example to be grateful for and celebrate.

[02:26:36] First, we've concluded a legislative session which we've tackled some of the most important pressing issues of challenging Virginia families in terms of affordability struggles at a time where we face headwinds with rising gas prices. We face a lot of issues that are impacting families but to the core of what the question was to the voters which to itself should be celebrated by the way other states have not taken that same approach the question was to the voters to decide

[02:27:10] the most pure form of democracy which is to ask the citizens the question themselves what should be done in the process of what they see is clearly going on in Washington was just to change votes before a midterm as to prescribe an outcome in a process that they also see that lacks a checks and balances process and I think what's also to be celebrated not only number one that a referendum occurred on the question whether it's approved or rejected the question has

[02:27:49] occurred and the voters have decided I think we've losing sight of that number two yesterday this body deliberated for six and a half hours roughly and what did we do we took up governor's amendments yes from the same party right triumvirate would control all branches right the House the Senate and the governor and what did this body do we deliberated we accepted we rejected we sent things back that we disagreed with the governor of our own party this

[02:28:21] chamber did what we are asking those in Congress to do which is to create the checks and balances and to do what was intended what was very formed in this building and the idea is that power concentrated can't happen because it corrodes it corrupts and the intentional separation both in the House and the Senate against the executive branch that we demonstrated in these halls just 12

[02:28:54] hours ago, 24 hours ago, excuse me, should be celebrated. This is the example and the message we're sending to America, not just Virginians, but to America, of how it should be done. Now, some of us may not agree with the outcome of the way the voters voted and decided, right? That's a part of having elections and winning and losing. We always don't agree with the outcomes. That's a part of our process, but the process itself should be what is also celebrated this week. This week was historic in many different aspects because of how the voters decided to say we're putting a foot

[02:29:31] down we want something different and we want washington to respect the checks and balances and respond differently and we've done just that not only that but following up with demonstrating through our actions yesterday and a robust debate today because i know all of us consider each other friends for those who are watching at home for all of those who just had debates for and against what we're talking about we are actually friends and we will pat on each other on the back about what's coming up vacations and other things and so what we see on the screen is not also often what it is in reality and so madam president i appreciate the time to celebrate which i think

[02:30:10] is so valuable and the foundational elements of our democracy that we exhibited this week madam president thank you thank you senator the chair recognizes the senior senator from henrico thank you madam chair i rise for a point of personal privilege senator has the floor thank you madam chair um my president madam president um i didn't intend to speak and that's what

[02:30:44] everyone's saying today um but as i reflect on when i first uh came to the general assembly which was just a little bit over a decade ago i believe we were at 66 that i was the 34th democrat in the

[02:31:09] house in in a special and I hear some folks say that certain demographics and certain groups of people improved in their numbers and some were black and that was largely to upset our colleagues and cause a divide and up in our caucus

[02:31:46] when I think about that process when you wanted your district to look a certain way. You had to go to two people in the house in leadership and plead your case and tell them how it worked for them if they drew your district more favorable. So there were a lot of districts that

[02:32:22] were extremely blue because individuals went to those two people and said this is how I want my district to look and it was acted favorably upon those two people and if you were in the house of delegates, you probably can name those two people.

[02:32:44] I don't care what side you're on. You know who those two people were. And we stayed in that super minority for quite some time. The same was true in the Senate.

[02:33:01] It wasn't until Democrats, the majorities in the House and the Senate, that we were able to get the commission.

[02:33:18] That didn't happen because all of a sudden Republicans changed their minds about fair maps. happened because they saw that Virginia was moving to a darker purple and they needed to get on board because we were taking the majority whether they got on board or not and so as we reflect that and we say in the Commonwealth many will

[02:33:54] argue we did the right thing but we disarmed and as it when you start looking at it nationally and when you start thinking about just this Congress that we have right now.

[02:34:15] Hakeem Jeffries would be the speaker right now if Virginia were still drawing their maps. We wouldn't have a 6-5.

[02:34:30] We would have a little bit more than that on the Democratic side. And as you think about how this plays out on a national level, we were perfectly fine with our 6-5.

[02:34:46] But again, what are we calling him? The man on the other side across the river decided to literally call states and demand that they take action.

[02:35:06] And it works on both sides. A lot of us have a hard time calling out our own leaders. And so when it happened in Texas, when it happened in Missouri, when it happened in North Carolina, it was crickets.

[02:35:27] And people wanted us to push back. We did that. And I think we did it in the same fashion we did it in 2020. We said the people get to make a choice. Now, as the people made the choice, and I hear it was a very close election, But don't forget, this is Virginia.

[02:35:52] Four years ago, they elected Yonkin. Things change in Virginia, and you know what? Virginians make up their own minds. And it was a tough decision.

[02:36:09] There are many Democrats that voted against this. Many Democrats. And let me tell you this. There are some Republicans that voted for it. And they voted for it because they believe what's going on is

not with they voted for. They did not vote for these wars. They did not vote for these gas prices. They voted for their lives to be improved. Like you said, electricity

[02:36:44] bills to go down. For somebody to look favorably amongst the farmers. And listen, I almost took issue with the other side saying that we don't understand. But I grew up watching the Waltons. I grew up with Opie. I even watched the Dukes of

[02:37:13] hasn't. I think I know a little bit about rural America. And when I think about why we are here, we're not just here. I'm not just here for Theo. I'm not just here for Arnold or Willis. I'm here

[02:37:49] for Opie, John Boyd, Bloxam, Topanga. We have to make sure that we keep this. It was a tough fight And I don't want the media to write as the headline for tomorrow, Republicans got up and gave a temper tantrum after the election.

[02:38:16] I don't want that. I want them to write a story that we all voiced our opinions and we walked away understanding that this land is your land and this land is my land.

[02:38:33] And we're going to fight on every corner of the Commonwealth to make sure that we deliver on the things that you all have said and the things that we have said. Because everybody's saying affordability.

[02:38:48] Everybody's saying they want lower electricity bills. Everybody's saying something about housing. Everybody says they want to protect the farmer. But we spend over an hour talking about him.

[02:39:05] And the chaos is where evil does its best work. We need to make sure that we refocus on both sides of the aisle on the task at hand.

[02:39:25] And I'll agree, we need a budget, but we need a budget that's going to work for the people of Virginia. And when we started this thing, no one ever thought that data centers would happen to be forced to pay their fair share.

[02:39:49] We want data centers here, I'll say that, I want data centers here, I want more business here in the Commonwealth but we want them to pay their fair share and it has to be sustainable we need to protect our water we need to protect our energy but we also need to not only begin complete sentences but be fair about it and when we talk about that budget I will guarantee you that this will be the best budget that any one of us have had since we start serving here and it's because

[02:40:25] we are making sure that folks are paying their fair share we are all focus on affordability, we're all focused on delivering, and our only competition should be who can do the most for Virginians. Thank you.

[02:40:40] Thank you, Senator. The chair now seeks unanimous consent to offer an hour-long rebuttal to both sides of the aisle. Seeing no other senators who wish to speak, the clerk will report any announcements on the desk.

[02:41:08] only have one announcement please note that all single house memorial and commending resolutions must be submitted one hour prior to the next meeting of the Senate for inclusion on the Senate calendar one hour the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax thank you madam president I would ask the Senate stand at ease for five minutes while we can leadership and go confer

[02:41:40] here for a second the senate will be at ease thank you madam president i move that the senate recess

[02:43:48] until reconvene with at least 48 hours notice by the call of the chair of the senate committee on rules and if you don't mind madam i lost my piece of paper uh what happened to we wanted to adjourn in honor and memory of former delegate, honorable Marian Van Landingham.

[02:44:20] - The question is, shall the Senate recess until reconvened with at least 48 hours notice by the call of the chair of the Senate Committee on Rules and that as we adjourn today, we do so in honor of the memory of former delegate, Marian Van Landingham.

[02:44:41] As many as are in favor of that motion, we'll say aye. - Aye. - Those opposed, no. The ayes have it, the motion is agreed to. The Senate now stands in recess.

[02:45:07] - This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[02:46:10] Senate chamber, be sure to stay connected

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[02:48:23] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[02:49:21] chamber.

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